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White-throated Sparrow

Zonotrichia albicollis

QUICK STATS

Length	6.3 – 7.1 in (16 – 18 cm)
Wingspan	7.9 – 9.1 in (20 – 23 cm)
Weight	0.8 – 1.1 oz (22 – 32 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The White-throated Sparrow is a large, handsome sparrow and a beloved winter visitor to feeders across eastern and southern North America. Its bold head pattern — alternating black and white crown stripes, a tiny yellow spot between bill and eye, and a sharply defined white throat — makes it one of the easiest sparrows to identify. Its haunting, whistled song, often transcribed as "Oh sweet Canada Canada Canada," is one of the most evocative sounds of the northern forest. The species comes in two distinct color morphs — white-striped and tan-striped — that interbreed freely but almost always choose mates of the opposite morph.

HABITAT & RANGE

The White-throated Sparrow breeds in the boreal forests of Canada and the northeastern United States, from British Columbia east to Newfoundland, south through the northern Great Lakes states and New England. It winters across the eastern half of the United States south to Florida and the Gulf Coast, and in smaller numbers west to California. On its breeding grounds it inhabits the edges of boreal forests, regenerating clear-cuts, and shrubby bogs. In winter it frequents woodland edges, brushy thickets, hedgerows, and suburban gardens with dense shrub cover.

DIET & FEEDING

- White millet — the top choice at feeders
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and hulled chips
- Cracked corn scattered on the ground
- Wild weed seeds: ragweed, smartweed, knotweed
- Wild berries: dogwood, sumac, bayberry
- Insects and spiders during the breeding season

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

White-throated Sparrows are gregarious in winter, foraging in flocks of 10–50 birds, often mixed with Dark-eyed Juncos, Song Sparrows, and other ground-feeding species. They are primarily ground feeders, scratching vigorously through leaf litter with a characteristic double-foot kick to expose buried seeds. The two color morphs — white-striped and tan-striped — represent a remarkable genetic polymorphism. White-striped birds are more aggressive and sing more frequently; tan-striped birds are better parents. Remarkably, nearly all mated pairs consist of one bird of each morph, a pattern maintained across the entire species.

NESTING & BREEDING

White-throated Sparrows nest on or near the ground in dense boreal shrub habitat. The female builds a cup nest of grasses, moss, and pine needles, hidden beneath shrubs or at the base of small trees. Clutches of 4–5 pale blue or greenish eggs with brown spotting are incubated by the female for 11–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 7–12 days. The species raises 1–2 broods per season. It is a frequent cowbird host on its breeding grounds.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The White-throated Sparrow's song is one of the most distinctive and beloved in North American birding — a clear, pure whistle often rendered as "Old Sam Peabody Peabody Peabody" or "Oh sweet Canada Canada Canada." It consists of 2–3 long introductory notes followed by a series of triplets on a different pitch. Males sometimes sing on warm winter days, though song peaks on the breeding grounds. The call is a sharp, metallic "chink."

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The White-throated Sparrow population is estimated at 140 million individuals but has declined significantly — by roughly 30% — since 1970, largely due to loss of boreal forest breeding habitat from logging and climate change. Maintaining dense shrub cover in winter gardens and reducing window collisions are meaningful ways to help this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Scatter white millet on the ground beneath feeders
- Dense shrub thickets nearby are essential — they retreat to cover constantly
- Low platform feeders or ground trays are preferred over tube feeders
- White-throated Sparrows often linger at feeders well into spring
- Reduce window collisions with decals — this species is particularly vulnerable

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown stripes	Bold black & white alternating
Yellow lore spot	Bright yellow — above bill/eye
Throat patch	Clean white — sharply defined
Back & wings	Brown, streaked dark
Breast & belly	Gray-white, unstreaked
Bill	Short, conical, pale gray-pink

COLOR ME!

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